

After a lean year in 2007, Nehwal bounced back to show her class and made 2008 her best year so far. Ironically, it is also the year of her biggest disappointment. An Olympic medal eluded Nehwal at Beijing though she has the distinction of becoming the first Indian woman to reach the quarter-finals, upsetting world No.5 and fourth seed Wang Chen of Hong Kong. "It was great representing my country and the biggest lesson I learnt was the need to control my nerves at crucial points," says Nehwal.

Before the Olympics, Nehwal had a hot streak in south Asia, reaching the quarter-finals of the Thailand Open Grand Prix Gold and the semi-final



THE DRAMATIC LEAP IN HER SPEED IS CONTRIBUTING TO CONSISTENCY

"Saina has all the attributes to be a world champion."

PRAKASH PADUKONE,
FORMER PLAYER

of the Singapore Super Series 2008. She also bagged the Chinese Taipei Grand Prix, her second Grand Prix, the Philippines Open and the Commonwealth Youth Games Championships before the World title came her way in Pune. "The Commonwealth Games contest was comparatively easy but it boosted my confidence," says Nehwal. Her sights are now set

much higher and much further. Ranked 11 currently, she knows that the climb into the top 10 in the world will take all her lung power and determination. She admits this is a "scary" thought, "for I need greater stamina and strength to face powerful players". Coach Gopichand says of her mission, "It is not always easy for her to keep winning and that she is still managing to do so is an indication of her ability to withstand pressure."

The gurus of the game have acknowledged her growth, including the greatest Prakash Padukone, who says, she has all the attributes to be a champion including "strokes and tenacity." He adds, "She does not give away points easily and is not cowed down by rivals." Badminton legend Dinesh Khanna points out that there is no woman player of her depth and calibre in the country, making her climb even tougher without high-quality sparring partners.

Nehwal's biggest assets is her understanding of her own game. Her aggression, sometimes leads to errors, and former coach, S. M. Arif says that the junior champion's biggest improvement has come in her speed. "However, she has to improve her backhand," warns the Dronacharya Award-winning coach. Nehwal's badminton genes are not well known, but her parents, Harvir Singh, an agricultural scientist at the Directorate of Oilseeds Research, Indian Council of Agricultural Research in Hyderabad and Usha Rani, were both more than capable badminton players in Haryana before the family moved to Hyderabad.

Nehwal's career has also blossomed at a critical time which has helped her financially. Apart from the government, the Champions Trust, instituted by London-based steel baron L.N. Mittal, chips in whenever she runs short of funds or needs to travel to tournaments. Her management firm Globosport has also helped her with some endorsement contracts.

Nehwal now has the biggest prize in age-group badminton but she knows she must follow her destiny elsewhere. Her eyes are now fixed on the All England Championship and the World Championship to be held in Hyderabad next year. She is pursuing the game with a maniacal devotion. "Seven hours of practice

every day sacrificing my collegiate education with a movie on Sundays as the only entertainment gives me the courage to face any challenge on court," says the first year B.Com. student of the St. Ann's College, Hyderabad. "I hope to do well but before that I have to break into the top 10 in the world," she adds. Given her grit, she probably will.